

Supporting skeleton

Without the skeleton, your body would collapse into a shapeless heap. Built from hard, strong bones, the skeleton not only holds up your body but also allows it to move. It surrounds organs such as the brain and heart, and protects them from damage caused by everyday knocks and jolts. Your bones also make blood cells and store calcium, a mineral that is essential for healthy teeth.

TWO SKELETONS

The skeleton can be divided into two main parts. The axial skeleton (cream) consists of the backbone, skull, ribs, and breastbone. It runs down the center of the body and supports and protects important organs. The appendicular skeleton (blue) consists of the arms and legs and the girdles that attach them to the axial skeleton.

▲ BONE NUMBERS

Eighty bones make up the axial skeleton. The appendicular skeleton has 126.

The shoulder (pectoral girdle) is formed by the clavicle and scapula bones.

The hip (pelvic girdle) is formed from two linked hipbones.

The kneecap (patella) protects the front of the knee joint.

The thighbone (femur) is the skeleton's biggest bone, and supports the weight of the upper body.

Your skeleton makes up around 20 percent of your body's weight.

The shinbone (tibia) links knee to ankle and carries most of the body's weight.

The fibula is the smaller lower leg bone that forms part of the ankle.

The metatarsal is one of the five sole bones in the foot.

FLEXIBLE FRAMEWORK

An adult skeleton is made up of 206 bones, many of which you can see in this model. The framework that these bones create is not rigid. Movable joints, such as the knee joint between the thighbone and shinbone, make the skeleton flexible. They allow the body to move when bones are pulled by muscles.